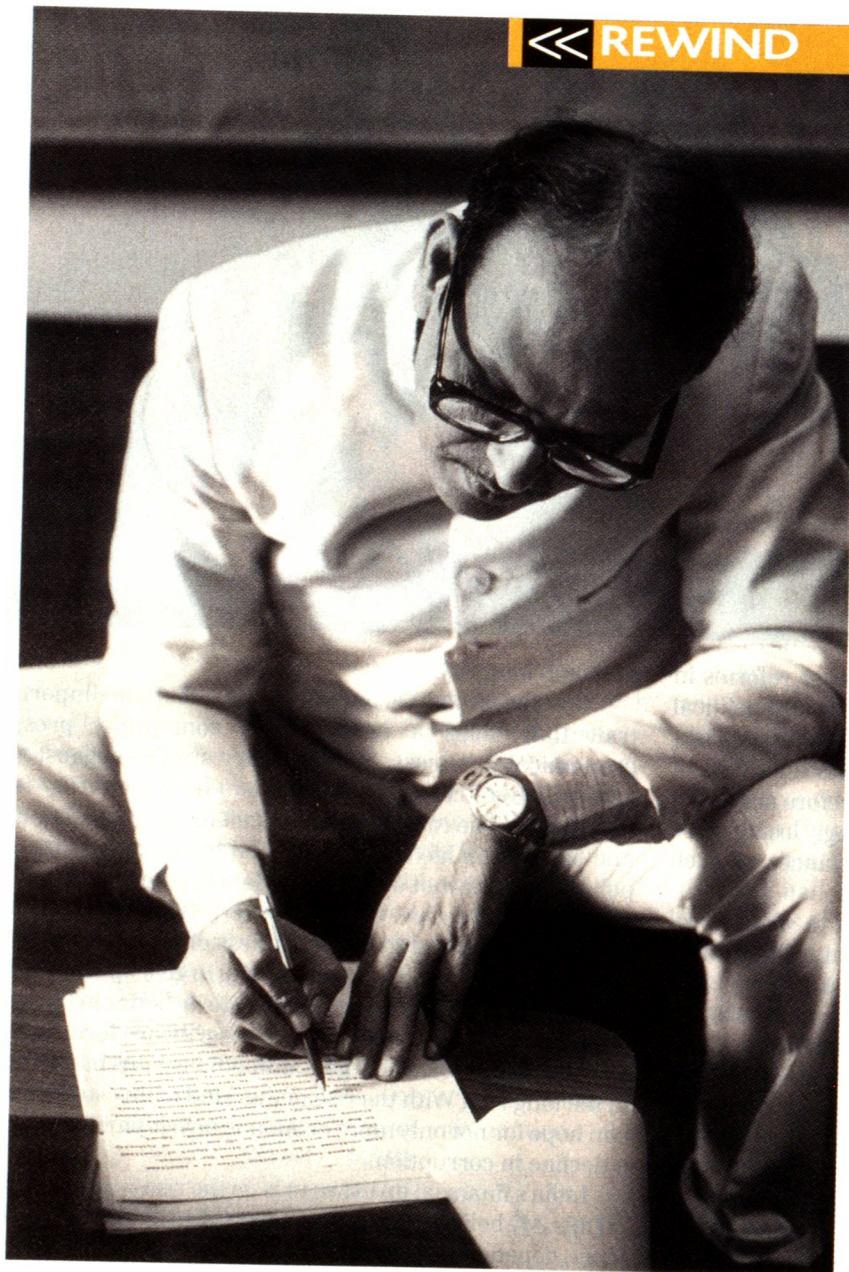


# CASTE CLEFT

◀◀ REWIND



It was just a four-paragraph government order implementing the recommendations of the Mandal Commission, set up in 1978. But for V.P. Singh, the prime minister of a coalition government, it blew the lid off the caste cauldron. With 27 per cent reservation in government jobs, schools and colleges for socially and educationally backward classes, it was a move to cleave the BJP's Hindu vote bank along caste lines. But it all went wrong as self-immolations and protestor-police battles created mini-Tiananmen Squares across India.

## COMING HOME

SHAYAM TEKWANI



The IPKF completed its pull-out from Sri Lanka as the last ship left with Indian soldiers.

## FIRST CUT

● On February 4, Ernakulam in Kerala was declared the first totally literate district in the country. The distinction, fittingly, came in International Literacy Year. Kerala

has the highest literacy in the country.

● The All Tripura Tiger Force was founded by Lalit Debbarma to fight for Tripura's secession from India.

## ◀◀ DID YOU KNOW

According to nuclear weapons specialist L.S. Spector, India, in 1990, had a capacity to produce 15 nuke warheads annually, but had made only 10 at the time.